twice a year. The land parcel would be given for a period of 60 years. The plantation—which cannot violate the Indian Forest Act 1927, the Forest Conservation Act 1980 or the Forest Rights Act 2006—can be done by the investor directly or via the MPFDC on payment of a fee. Care has to be taken to ensure that adequate land is left around villages to meet the local community's needs in the form of grazing or collection of firewood.

The policy claims to have built in local consent to protect community rights. But activists are worried. "The moment a private company is brought in, it will safeguard its interests. It would not allow unhindered access to the community. In tribal areas, where there are traditional forest rights related to faith, that may come in conflict with private interests too," cautions social activist Sachin Jain, founder, Vikas Samvad.

Structural shifts in ownership are certainly built in. The investor would have the right to sell half the minor forest produce (MFP), like tendu leaves, mahua and chironji; the MPFDC would get 30 per cent and 20 per cent would be left for the local communities. Presently, communities dwelling in and around forests have rights over all MFPs. The investor, who will get green credits for afforestation as per the Forest (Conservation) Amendment Act 2023, would also have the first right to buy the MFP allocated to the MPFDC.

The afforestation norms are laid rationally—on paper. Preference would be for local species; exotic plant species will not be allowed. A 75 per cent survival rate would have to be ensured after three years. In case of a deficit, the executing agency will bridge the gap. If the survival rate in a plantation executed by the MPFDC falls below 40 per cent, the entire cost would be reimbursed to the investor. Crucially, after three years, the investor would be responsible for protecting the plantation.

Jain says granting greater rights to the community over forests would have sufficed to protect them, rather than bringing in private investors. "The government should tread cautiously on this front," he counsels. ■



PTI

THAT SINKING FEELING A flooded neighbourhood in Vadodara after the Vishwamitri river breached its banks due to heavy rain in Aug. 2024

VADODARA

DELUGE OF DOUBTS

By Jumana Shah

Six months after Vadodara witnessed one of its worst floods in recent history, the Rs 1,200 crore Vishwamitri River Rejuvenation Project—announced by the Gujarat government to restore the river's carrying capacity and mitigate future flooding—is finally inching forward, but on a somewhat contentious course.

Once the city's lifeline, the Vishwamitri has now become a symbol of its struggle to balance development and ecological preservation. Last August, 9.4 inches of rain over 24 hours left 40 per cent of the city submerged in up to 11 feet of water for three days. As the Ajwa and Pratapgarh reservoirs overflowed, water poured into the Vishwamitri, which once had floodplains, wetlands and lakes connected by natural waterways—now largely replaced by concrete structures. With the river breaching its banks, marsh crocodiles wandered into kitchens and streets, while residents were stranded in posh bungalows and apartment buildings.

A study by IIT Gandhinagar found the flood was "likely exacerbated by extensive urban development in flood-prone areas, altered elevations, and drainage patterns compromised due to rapid urbanisation and clogged drainage systems". The tragedy, many argue, was a foretold one.

Two citizen groups—the Community Science Centre (CSC), led by scientist Dr M.H. Mehta, and the Concerned Citizens of Vadodara